

Defining Technical Assistance for the Housing Reconstruction Discussion Paper

Introduction

This document has been developed to support efforts to define the minimum requirements for Technical Assistance (TA) to support the housing reconstruction.

The HRRP advocates for Partner Organisations (POs) to prioritise TA for the housing reconstruction in order to add value to the efforts and investments made by families and communities themselves, and to support the Government of Nepal (GoN) housing grant disbursement.

Objectives of Technical Assistance

The overall aim / goal of technical assistance is that **all affected households reconstruct or rehabilitate their homes and communities compliant with standards within 4 years**. Achieving this will depend on the coverage, quality, and timeliness of the delivery of technical assistance. This can be represented as follows

Number of houses constructed	↔	Coverage of technical assistance
Quality of construction	↔	Quality of technical assistance
Time to construct	↔	Timeliness of technical assistance delivery

The minimum requirements for technical assistance are proposed as follows:

- All families and communities reconstructing and repairing their homes will have access to timely and appropriate advice to build back safer and more sustainable houses and human settlements, and are adequately supported through the inspection process.
- The availability of skilled construction workers will be increased and improved to facilitate reconstruction.
- Reconstruction will build long term community resilience.

The above minimum requirements provide an indication of the base level of support that should be available to all earthquake affected communities as they go through their reconstruction process.

Implementation Options for Technical Assistance

The HRRP recognises that reconstruction actors may approach technical assistance in different ways and use different approaches. The implementation options presented below are what the HRRP suggests as some options to achieve the minimum requirements for technical assistance.

Orientation / Awareness Raising Sessions

- Personnel – the mobile technical assistance team(s) in the VDC will be responsible for delivering the orientation / awareness raising sessions. Where possible GoN resource person(s) should also join the orientation sessions.
- Content – as a minimum sessions should cover the inspection SOP and associated compliance criteria, the process for the disbursement of the housing grant, grievance redressal mechanism, seismic construction elements, earthquake preparedness (go bags, 'drop, cover, hold', etc.), household WASH, and relevant contact people (GoN and POs). Content should be updated regularly to reflect changes to policy / procedures, as well as the progress through the reconstruction process. Materials such as posters, leaflets, and booklets which can be taken away after the orientation sessions should be available to households.
- The mobile technical assistance teams should deliver the orientations at ward level, moving through each of the 9 wards on a repeat cycle. It is suggested that sessions should be delivered as follows:
 - House by house – the orientation team should start the orientation process by conducting house by house sessions. Normally house by house sessions will take approximately 30 minutes per house. Questions raised during these sessions should be documented and materials for group sessions should be updated to incorporate this. These questions should also be shared to district and national level for compilation and sharing.

- Group sessions – these sessions should follow the house by house sessions and should be held at a time that is appropriate for the community. The orientation team may need to consider conducting sessions for different target groups within the community, e.g. elderly people, women, young people, etc., where required. Group sessions should be conducted at least three times to ensure that people have multiple opportunities to access the information and should be at least a 4 hour long session. Questions raised in the group sessions should be documented, and shared to district and national level for compilation and sharing.
- Information Hubs – once the house by house and group sessions are completed, the orientation team will on a periodic basis set up an ‘information hub’ in the ward to provide opportunities for households to access information as they need it. These hubs may be a fixed point where households can come and ask questions, collect information materials, and also from which the mobile teams can conduct follow up house by house visits as required.

Training for Artisans / Construction Workers

- Training is required at scale to ensure that there is sufficient skilled labour available to deliver the housing reconstruction. Training must be delivered in coordination with the NRA, the MoUD CL-PIU, and DUDBC and must follow the [NRA’s training facilitation and management guidelines](#), and align with the NRA’s training strategy (soon to be published). The overall scope of training for the reconstruction is very broad, but at VDC level specific to the housing reconstruction the following training opportunities should be available across all wards of the VDC (trainings may not be carried out at ward level because of logistics etc.):
 - Training on seismic resistant elements for existing masons, 7 day DUDBC Curriculum
 - Training on seismic resistant elements for existing carpenters, 5 days CTEVT Curriculum (currently being developed, expected to be finalised soon)
 - On the Job Training for new masons, 50 day curriculum to be carried out as part of construction of a demonstration house

Mobile Technical Assistance Teams

- Composition – mobile TA teams should include technical resources person(s) and social mobilisation resource person(s), ideally with one engineer, one social mobiliser, and one technician (generally a master mason). The technician may not be required full time, or throughout the duration of the reconstruction and should be engaged to coincide with peak times in construction, and in some cases there may even be scope to consider more than one technician per VDC.
- Role – the mobile TA teams will be responsible for providing door to door, household level technical support through the duration of the reconstruction. This support should be provided at village level and should cover technical, social, financial, and policy / procedure aspects of the reconstruction.
- Frequency and Scheduling of Visits – visits should be carried out on a rolling basis and should be scheduled to align with key timings in the construction process as per the compliance criteria, and in particular in relation to the points for tranche disbursement.
- Activities – mobile TA teams will conduct orientation / awareness raising sessions, carry out household visits, collect frequently asked questions, raise technical issues to VDC cluster and district level and share technical solutions back to the households, and support training and demonstration construction.

Options for Supplementary Technical Assistance Activities

The above minimum requirements, should not be seen to limit the scope of technical assistance. There are a number of supplementary activities which can be delivered where possible. These include, but are not limited to, the following:

Support for vendors and fabricators: Vendors and fabricators may be mobilised as partners in the promotion of awareness of the importance of quality assurance in safer construction. They represent a fixed point of reference for households and communities, where they can access information and guidance regarding materials and their use for construction. Activities could include tracking of information such as contacts, capacity, materials available, supply, range, type, quality, cost, etc., providing training and technical advice for quality assurance, promotion and awareness

events at vendor premises, providing training on material quality and GoN guidance, and providing employment and skills development opportunities.

Awareness activities with schools and young people: The population profile in Nepal is very young, and investment in youth as change agents is a key strategy to achieve broad social sensibilisation and behaviour change. Activities could include providing teaching and learning resources to local schools, holding orientation sessions in schools, organising debates within or between schools to explore and consider issues and articulate information and arguments, field visits / walkabouts, practical exercises such as collecting and measuring rainwater, and competitions such as essay writing, drawing, quizzes, etc. within and between schools.

Interactive mobile cinema and theatre: Interactive mobile cinema or mobile theatre is a public information, education and entertainment event. The programme can include prepared audio visual or dramatic content on particular subjects, such as safer construction, locally generated content, live discussions, and additional entertainment content. Cinema or theatre used should be based on local research and participation to capture pertinent questions and local practices and should involve local representatives. The scale and complexity of the event can vary according to resources, location and target audiences and can be useful to target large groups of people.

Community exchange visits: Provide opportunities for community members from one area to visit another area, to learn about initiatives and projects, and to listen to and discuss the host and visitor community's reconstruction experiences. Such visits ensure wider exposure for small scale / pilot projects, and can facilitate visiting communities to make more informed choices for their own areas. Visits should be two way if possible, and where possible visits should also be repeated so that communities can learn from each throughout the whole reconstruction process. In all visits it is advisable that the host and visiting group is representative of their respective communities, including those directly involved in construction, women and young people as well as men. Local and technical government representatives should participate from both communities. Communities should be encouraged to develop a network of exchange and resource persons of reference to represent and promote experience and expertise.